

10 Ways German Research Is Different from U.S. Research

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1. **Language:** English vs. German.

Language is the key identifying factor for what is or was “Germany.” Think of Germany as the contiguous area where German is spoken. Genealogists don’t need conversational German, travel German, German literature, or scientific German for our uses. We need basic German genealogical terminology. English and German have the same alphabet, with a few extra characters, and German spelling is much more predictable than English.

2. **The Written Word:** Roman vs. *Fraktur*.

The standard printed word in English-language publications is the Roman or Antiqua style of type font. The printed word in German publications until 1941 was the *Fraktur* style of type font. Since 1941 German publications use the Roman style of type font.

3. **Handwriting:** Cursive vs. *Kurrent*.

The writing in American manuscripts is cursive script, used in schools until about 2010, when some schools started teaching only handwritten print letters, but 27 states now mandate or strongly encourage cursive handwriting.

The standard handwriting in German manuscripts was called *Kurrent* until 1915. Prussian schools since 1915 and all German schools after 1934 were mandated to teach a handwriting system called *Sütterlin*, named after its inventor. In 1941 a modern style resembling English cursive was mandated.

4. **Surnames:** Anglicized vs. Original.

There were no “Name Change Officials,” but of course names did get written in many different ways in America by immigrants themselves or other people writing down names – clergy, officials, clerks, census enumerators, editors, etc. Many names were transformed in early Pennsylvania. Surname pitfalls to look for in Germany are spelling variations (Schmid, Schmidt, Schmit, Schmitt), patronymics, and farm names.

5. **Given Names:** First, Middle, Last vs. Several Names and Last (Called by *Rufname*.)

The common American system for filling out forms is first name, middle name or initial, and last name. Germans don’t and didn’t have that concept. If several given names are listed in a legal document, the name used by people, the *Rufname* (what they are actually called by people) usually is noted with a mark or an underline. Some names are translatable like English Mary from German (or Latin) Maria, and some are nicknames or familiar names, like Fritz from Friedrich.

6. **Place Names:** County, State, Country vs. German *Kreis*(etc.), *Bezirk*(etc.), *Land*(etc.)

The hierarchy of places changes greatly over time. In the U.S. part of Massachusetts became Maine, part of Virginia became West Virginia, Texas had 6 different flags. There were hundreds of rulers in German lands in the 1700s. They were governed by a pecking-order of rulers: Emperor>King>Grand Duke>Duke>Prince>Free City. There were others, like Bishops and Margraves and Barons and Counts. We won't "count" them. After World War II there was "West" and "East" Germany. Before the war Germany included Prussian areas further east, now mostly Polish. Large jurisdictions aren't primary in German genealogy; it is the small village with a civil registry or a parish church where the records were made and are kept. Even if you find the name of the place in American records, it may not be a unique name, or worse, it will be badly misspelled.

7. **Dates:** July 4, 1776 vs. den 4. VII. 1776 / 04.07.1776

German date conventions are different. American month/day/year becomes German day/month/year. The Julian to Gregorian calendar switch took place at different times. Latin festival names are common. The French devised a calendar used west of the Rhine. Some areas used archaic names for months. Date conversion tables can be found online.

8. **Record Types:** State/National vs. Local/Regional

U.S. vital records are usually kept at the city/county and state levels. All German birth, marriage, and death records were kept locally. The U.S. has federal and some state censuses. German lands did take censuses, but each with their own local titles, possibly in local archives. The U.S. has military draft and service records, U.S. land records can be found at the federal, state, and county levels; German plat owners in a local *Grundbuch*.

9. **Sources:** National/State Archives vs. *Stadtarchiv*/*Genealogiegruppe*

Besides holding records locally, Germans like to collect genealogy of their own historic local region. Look for the local *Verein* or *Gesellschaft* or *Arbeitskreis*. The *Bundesarchiv* holds recent records mostly since World War II, probably too recent for ancestral research.

10. **Immigration/Emigration**

Researchers on both sides of "the pond" want to cross it. American immigrants are found in passenger arrival lists from port cities and in naturalization records. German emigrants (the same people) are found in passenger embarkation lists and requests for permission to leave. A great source for these is the required legal notice of intent to emigrate, and with many newspaper digitizations it is possible to search for these by name and/or locality.

Language

https://www.familysearch.org/en/wiki/German_Genealogical_Word_List

Thode, Ernest, *German-English Genealogical Dictionary*

Printed Word

<https://script.byu.edu/german-handwriting/alphabet/gothic-typefaces>

https://www.pgdp.net/wiki/Anyone_can_learn_Fraktur

Handwriting

ABCs of German Script

https://gfo.org/file_download/inline/6357095e-cc46-4ca9-8a15-c2789318295b

Witter's German School Primer

<https://mki.wisc.edu/wp-content/uploads/sites/1100/2024/01/Witter-Fibel-1904-1.pdf>

Fraktur and *Kurrent* Print Generator <https://stevemorse.org/script/printcurs.html>

Kurrent Lowercase and Uppercase (1800s-1900s)

<https://script.byu.edu/german-handwriting/alphabet/alphabet-charts>

Lowercase 1600s-1700s www.suetterlinschrift.de/Lese/Kanzlei1.htm

Uppercase 1600s-1700s www.suetterlinschrift.de/Lese/Kanzlei2.htm

Surnames

Geographic distribution of surnames www.namenskarte.com

Surname distribution 1890 and 1996 <https://nvk.genealogy.net/map>

Digital Dictionary of Surnames in Germany <https://www.namenforschung.net/dfd/>

Telephone Directory of Germany <https://www.dastelefonbuch.de/>

Bahlow, Hans, *Dictionary of German Names*

Jones, George F., *German-American Names*

Given Names

<https://script.byu.edu/german-handwriting/introduction>

German masculine given names

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Category:German_masculine_given_names

German feminine given names

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Category:German_feminine_given_names

Place Names

www.meyersgaz.org (gazetteer of German localities in 1912 at largest extent)

<https://onlinestreet.de/strassen/> (streets & roads often have names of tiny, obscure places)

<https://gov.genealogy.net/search/index> (German place jurisdictions through history)

<http://www.kartenmeister.com/preview/databaseuwe.asp> (Prussian provinces in the East)

<https://www.jewishgen.org/communities/loctown.asp> (phonetic searches, 63 countries)

Map of Prussia and the German Empire as of 1907 from Leibniz Institut:

http://de.wikipedia.org/wiki/Liste_der_Reichstagswahlkreise_des_Deutschen_Kaiserreichs

Dates

<https://stevemorse.org> (scroll to subsection Calendar)

https://www.familysearch.org/en/wiki/Julian_and_Gregorian_Calendars

(adoption dates of Gregorian calendar in various regions)

Record Types

<https://www.ekd.de/en/index.htm> (**Protestant church parishes**)

<https://www.compgen.de/2023/12/pfarreifinder-und-pfarreienverzeichnis-fuer-katholische-gemeinden-in-deutschland/> (**Catholic church parishes**)

German Immigrants in American Church Records, called **GIACR**, 47 volumes (thus far) of church books in America, the **best** type of source to find a Location, Location, Location.

<https://rpmgrtpublications.wixsite.com/mysite/about-1>

German Emigration Center Bremerhaven

<https://www.dah-bremerhaven.de/en>

German Emigrant Museum Hamburg

<https://ballinstadt.de/>

Totenzettel (memorial cards)

<https://wgff-tz.de/>

German World War I MIAs and Graves

<https://www.volksbund.de/erinnern-gedenken/graebersuche-online> (

Melderegister, filed by address: Town *Meldeamt*. Give name, address, and residence date.

Ahnennpass, mostly kept within the family, a few at archives

US National Archives (**Nazi membership cards** with name, birth date, local chapter, often a photo; MKFL alphabetically filed, MFOK filed by local group)

<https://catalog.archives.gov/search-within/12044361>

Arolsen Archives on Nazi persecution

<https://arolsen-archives.org/en/> ()

Entnazifizierung/Denazification (1.2M denazification files here, also regional archives)

<https://www.archivportal-d.de/objekte?query=entnazifizierung>

CompGen, Society for Computer Genealogy, metasearch of several databases

<https://meta.genealogy.net/>

GenWiki, a collaborative German genealogy research wiki

<https://wiki.genealogy.net/Hauptseite>

Archives

Matricula Catholic church books, Germany and Austro-Hungary

<https://data.matricula-online.eu/en/suchen/>

Archion church books of Protestant Germany, also of Hildesheim, Speyer, Trier Catholic dioceses, now totaling 200,000 church books

<https://www.archion.de/en/>

IGGP (worldwide German genealogical research partnership)

<https://iggp.org/>

ArcInSys (finding aids for Lower Saxony/Bremen, Schleswig-Holstein, and Hessen)

<https://www.arcinsys.niedersachsen.de/arcinsys/start>

<https://arcinsys.schleswig-holstein.de/arcinsys/start>

<https://arcinsys.hessen.de/arcinsys/start>

Immigration/Emigration

Zeitungsportal (German historic newspapers, online, searchable)

<https://www.deutsch-anno.onb.ac.at/e-digitale-bibliothek.de/newspaper>

BSB DigiPress (German historic newspapers, online, searchable, especially Bavaria)

<https://digipress.digital-sammlungen.de/search/simple>

ANNO Austrian Empire historic newspapers, online, searchable

<https://anno.onb.ac.at/>

Swiss historic newspapers online, searchable

<https://www.e-newspaperarchives.ch/?l=en>

Prussian historic newspapers

<https://zefys.staatsbibliothek-berlin.de/search/>